

Watery Eyes

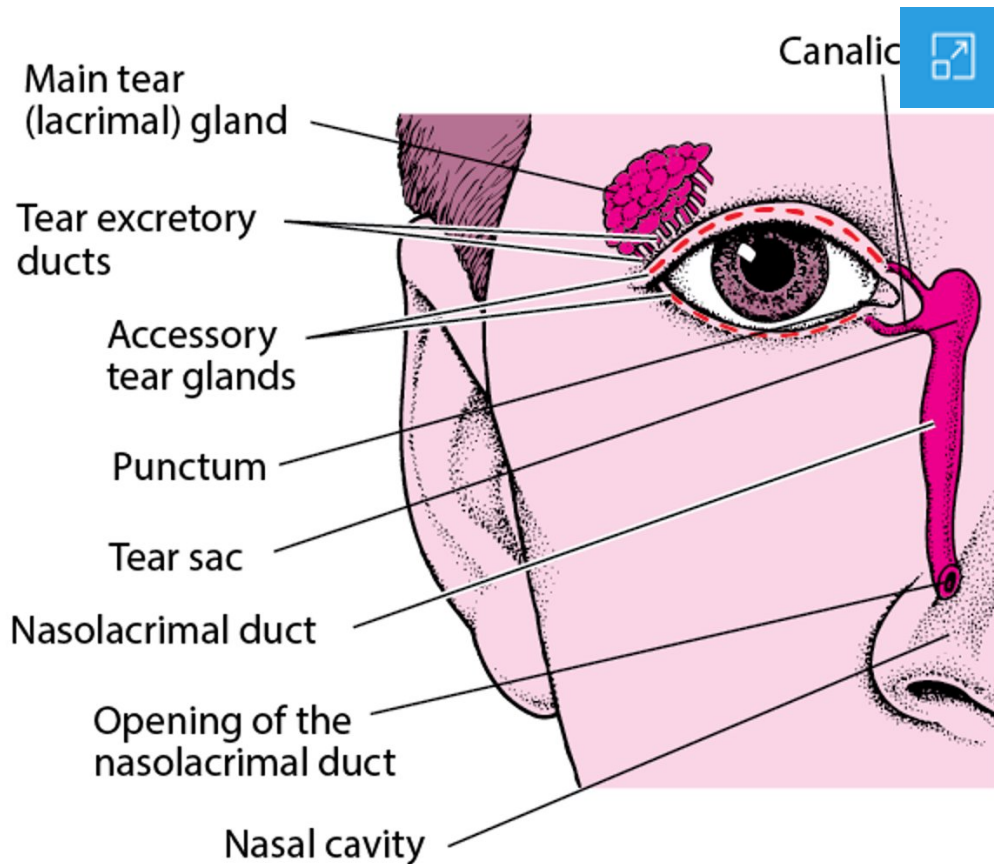
(Excess Tearing)

By **Christopher J. Brady**, MD, Larner College of Medicine, University of Vermont
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Excess tearing may cause a sensation of watery eyes or result in tears falling down the cheek. Other symptoms, such as eye irritation or pain, may be present depending on the cause.

Most tears are produced in the tear (lacrimal) glands located above the outer part of the upper eyelid. Tears run across the eye and drain through small openings at the inner corners of the eyelids near the nose (the upper and lower puncta) into short channels (the canaliculi). They then run into the tear sac and through the nasolacrimal duct into the nose. Blockage anywhere along the tear drainage pathway can lead to a watery eye. Blockage also predisposes to infection of the tear sac ([dacryocystitis](#)). Such infection can sometimes spread to tissues around the eye ([periorbital cellulitis](#)).

Where Tears Come From



Causes of Watery Eyes

Watery eyes can be caused by increased tear production or blockage of tear drainage (see table [Some Causes and Features of Watery Eyes](#)).

Common causes of watery eyes are

- Upper respiratory infections
- Allergies that affect the nose ([allergic rhinitis](#)), eyes ([allergic conjunctivitis](#)), or both

Other causes include

- [Dry eyes](#) (the dry surface of the eye becomes irritated, the tear glands produce "reflex" tears, and thus, surprisingly, dry eyes can cause watery eyes)

- Inwardly turned eyelid ([entropion](#)) or eyelashes that rub against the eyeball ([trichiasis](#))
- An outwardly turned eyelid ([ectropion](#)) that moves the punctum away from its normal position next to the eyeball so that it cannot drain away tears
- Age-related narrowing of the tear ducts, called [acquired dacryostenosis](#)
- Chronic infections in the tear sac, called [dacryocystitis](#)

Any disorder that irritates the cornea (the clear layer in front of the iris and pupil) can increase tear production. However, most people with [corneal disorders](#) that cause watery eyes (such as a corneal scratch or sore, a foreign object in the eye, or inflammation of the cornea) have significant pain, redness, and/or sensitivity to light, which are the usual reasons they seek medical care.



Some Causes and Features of Watery Eyes

Cause	Common Features*
Disorders that cause excess tear production	
	Watering that is worse when eyes are exposed to cold or windy weather, cigarette smoke, or dry heat
<u>Dry eyes</u>	A feeling of something in the eye (foreign object [body] sensation) that comes and goes, especially toward the end of the day
Irritation of the eye surface due to	
• <u>Conjunctivitis</u> (inflammation of the membrane that lines the back of the eyelid and covers the front of the eye) caused by allergies, chemicals, or infection	Eye redness In people with allergic conjunctivitis, itching
• <u>Blepharitis</u> (inflammation of the edges of the eyelids)	In people with an inwardly turned eyelid and eyelashes, often a sensation of grittiness or something in the eye
• <u>Entropion</u> (an inwardly turned eyelid) and <u>trichiasis</u> (inwardly turned eyelashes)	In people with corneal scratch or foreign body, pain, light sensitivity, and a sensation of grittiness or something in the eye
• <u>Corneal scratches and foreign body</u> (scratches or foreign objects involving the surface of the transparent dome on the front surface of the eye)	
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Nasal irritation caused by allergies or an upper respiratory infection	Runny nose, sneezing, and nasal congestion
Disorders that block tear drainage	
<u>Congenital dacryostenosis</u> (blockage of a tear duct that is present at birth)	Symptoms that begin weeks after birth